

Consumer preferences towards animal-friendly fashion products: an application to the Italian market

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper aims to examine consumer preference for ethical fashion products by focusing on the importance of animal welfare attribute. To explain the attitude-behavior gap, this research proposes to explore the costs and sacrifices associated with the adoption of responsible behaviors.

Design/methodology/approach – To analyze in which manner the animal welfare attribute impacts the consumer preference, the authors carried two quantitative studies in the Italy context. The first one ($n = 224$) proposes to measure the importance of this attribute in the case of luxury vs accessible fashion. The second study ($n = 101$) examines how the attention given to animal welfare information could vary between prosocials and proselves. Conjoint analyses that consider “proportion of real fur”; “information about animal treatment” and “price” attributes have been realized. To take into account the individuals characteristics, cluster analysis helped to identify different profiles of consumers.

Findings – The results reveal that even if consumers continue to prefer products made entirely from animal fur, they are sensitive to the information on the animal treatment conditions. Also, the animal welfare is not the most important criterion in explaining preference for a fashion product. This result varies, however, regarding the consumers’ social value orientation. Individuals with a high level of prosocial values give more importance to the animal welfare attribute and are less reluctant to the reduction of the proportion of real fur in the clothes. Proself consumers associate a higher sacrifice with the consumption of animal-friendly fashion products.

Research limitations/implications – This research enriches the limited literature on the consumers’ response to animal-friendly products. By considering the consumers’ social value orientation, it provides a better understanding of the attitude-behavior gap in animal-friendly fashion consumption. However, further studies should focus on the way of adapting communication on eco-products to the consumer profile. Moreover, it seems interesting to explore how the integration of innovative environmentally friendly materials can be accepted by the target. Replicating this research with representative consumer samples from different countries is also necessary.

Practical implications – From a practical point of view, this research offers implications for managers operating in fashion apparel industry by giving insights on the consumers’ preference for animal friendly fashion.

Social implications – This study gives recommendations to help convincing consumers about the importance of animal welfare attribute and to increase their preference for animal-friendly fashion products.

Originality/value – Despite the extensive use of animal fibers, fur and skins in the production of textiles, the few researchers who have shed the light on the consumers’ response to animal-friendly products have considered mainly the case of food. Also, the marketing literature gives little explanation of the attitude-behavior gap in ethical fashion consumption. By examining the consumers’ social value orientation, this study provides a better understanding of this gap.

Keywords Fashion industry, Animal welfare, Conjoint analysis, Consumers’ preference, Proselfs, Prosocials

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

Globalization conducted to more complex supply chains that become increasingly dispersed across the world. The fashion

industry is particularly concerned with this trend; many companies have chosen to relocate their production to developing countries to benefit from lower costs. [Laudal \(2010\)](#) notes that around 70% of clothes used in the European Union come from developing countries. This movement has led to the emergence of new social issues. In recent years, a number of accidents in clothing factories have been the subject

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of extensive media coverage due to their magnitude. For instance, in 2012, a fire at a clothing factory in Karachi (Pakistan) killed more than 300 workers; and in 2013, the collapse of Rana Plaza in Bangladesh killed 1,100 people (Lund-Thomsen and Lindgreen, 2014).

In addition, there have been several scandals involving animals in recent years: for example, newspaper articles (Bolton, 2015) have shown videos of animal cruelty in crocodile farms particularly in Texas and Zimbabwe. Such scandals have forced brands to react through two kinds of strategic actions. On the one hand, some companies have maintained their use of raw animal materials in production but have included some initiatives in their supply chain. For instance, the Italian textile brand Loro Piana, as part of its commitment since 1994 to protect the vicuña, created the first nature reserve in Peru in 2008. Other companies have taken more effort by opting for vertical integration. This is the case with LVMH and Hermès, which have bought crocodile farms in Australia. On the other hand, some brands like Stella McCartney have decided to replace animal leather with an environmentally friendly raw material.

The different strategic actions that aim to ensure animal welfare may raise questions about their impact on business performance. According to De Jonge and Van Trijp (2013), from a long-term perspective, taking into account the animal welfare issue offers different advantages: improving market access when there are strict retailer demands, enhancing production efficiency and providing added value to the products. However, other authors (Vaarst and Alroe, 2012) pointed out that, in practice, creating a farming system in which animals are able to satisfy their natural behavior involves a lot of investment. In the same way, De Jonge and Van Trijp (2013) argued that this choice could be a source of significant uncertainty, especially in terms of consumer's willingness to pay a premium for the animal welfare attribute. Animal welfare could be defined based on three levels: the animals should feel well, they should function well and they should lead a natural life (express their natural behavior). Animal suffering occurs when animals "experience something difficult or painful that is too prolonged and too severe to cope with, as induced by human subjectivity" (Planthoin, 2016, p. 62).

To our knowledge, little research has examined the consumer response to the animal welfare information, hence the relevance of this study. More particularly, our research aims to determine the consumer preference for animal-friendly products, in the specific case of fashion industry.

Recent studies (Reimers *et al.*, 2016) suggest that animal welfare has a strong influence on the consumer perception of ethical fashion, especially in the case of accessible brands. This raises the question of whether the consumer sensitivity for the animal welfare is also important in the luxury sector where the use of animal raw materials is a generalized practice. This issue is of major concern to the luxury clothing industry as the use of sustainable substitute materials (e.g. synthetic fur) may decrease the perceived quality and the ostentatious value of luxury products (Dekhili *et al.*, 2019), and thus could be associated to a high perceived sacrifice for the consumer.

The costly signaling theory (Zahavi, 1975) with social values orientation approach (Messick and McClintock, 1968) shed useful light on the question. Following this theory, consumers

can accept to purchase responsible luxury products, even perceived of lower quality, to satisfy their need for status (Griskevicius *et al.*, 2010). According to Zabkar and Hosta (2013), engaging in responsible behavior is generally synonymous of higher costs for the consumer as such, it can, on one hand, act as a communicative signal of a persons' capacity to pay high prices, and on the other hand, be used as a means of signaling that the person is "prosocial", rather than a "proself". The combined use of the literature on costly signaling theory and that on social values orientation will contribute to a better understanding of consumer perception of animal welfare attribute. In particular, it will give new insights into the costs and sacrifices notions associated with the adoption of responsible behavior (De Groot and Steg, 2009; Cameron *et al.*, 1998).

In view of the complexity of ethical clothing consumption (Jägel *et al.*, 2012), addressing in this article the animal welfare issue could help explain the attitude-behavior gap that is usually observed in this product category (Joergens, 2006).

2. Literature review

2.1 Emergence of slow fashion and importance of animal welfare in consumer preference

"Fast fashion" refers to goods that are mass-produced, cheap, fashionable and with a fast stock turnaround (Henninger *et al.*, 2015). This production model, introduced by Inditex Group and H&M, adopts a philosophy of just-in-time and rapid response to frequently renew the fashion offer and thus maintain strong market growth. It is based on the principle of planned obsolescence, which encourages the regular emergence of new styles and thus stimulates the consumer to buy new products (Kim and Hall, 2015). Fast fashion model also encourages more rapid disposal of fashion apparel (Nagurney *et al.*, 2015). The average weight of clothing that is rejected by a typical American each year is about 30 kg (Ha-Brookshire and Hodges, 2009).

The fashion industry is also generally held responsible for major social issues causing the death of more than 50 million animals a year (Born Free USA, 2014). It is strongly associated with the intensive use of animal fibers (e.g. skin and fur) (Sneddon *et al.*, 2010). In addition, most mass-market retailers, such as H&M, Nike and Zara procure their materials from developing countries where social production conditions are unfavorable. For instance, the monthly wage in 2013 of a worker in the fashion industry remains very low (39\$ per month in Bangladesh, 80\$ in Cambodia, 71\$ in India, 79\$ in Pakistan, 73\$ Sri Lanka and 78\$ in Vietnam) (Haque and Azmat, 2015).

In contrast to fast fashion, which focuses on aesthetic values (self-oriented values), ethical fashion considers extrinsic factors, such as the conditions of clothing factory workers and the protection of the environment. Ethical fashion "incorporates fair trade principles with sweatshop-free labor conditions while not harming the environment or workers by using biodegradable and organic cotton" (Joergens, 2006, p. 361).

Some authors (Henninger *et al.*, 2015) use the term of "slow fashion", which encompasses all the "sustainable", "eco", "green" and "ethical" fashion movements. This new model not only encourages the slowing down of production and

consumption processes but also advocates the protection of workers, communities and the environment (Ertekin and Atik, 2015).

Ethical fashion nevertheless remains a very small part of the fashion sector, representing approximately 1% of the world supply (Phau *et al.*, 2015). This weak development can be explained by several factors:

- the incompatibility between the principles of CSR and the low-cost economic model on which a large number of fashion brands are based (Doorey, 2011);
- the difficulty to implement CSR among suppliers in developing countries (Stabile, 2000); and
- the gap between the increasing social and environmental Western consumers' concerns and their purchasing behavior (Achabou and Dekhili, 2015).

Regarding the latter, consumers still not willing to sacrifice products' functional attributes in favor of the ethical ones. A recent empirical study conducted on the French market (Achabou and Dekhili, 2015) confirmed that ethical attributes are not an important differentiation factor in the fashion market. In this vein, Eder-Hansen *et al.* (2012) have shown that there is a widespread belief that sustainable garments are neither elegant nor fashionable, and that the design and appearance of eco-garments are outdated or even frumpy. Globalization has distanced people from the environmental and social consequences of the products they consume (Ertekin and Atik, 2015). Thus, individuals can be unwilling to adopt environmentally friendly behaviors because of feeling too physically and culturally distanced from the problems caused (Lyon, 2006).

If the literature on sustainability has placed the issue of human well-being and environmental footprint at the center of its concern, animal welfare has long been ignored. According to Planthorn (2016, p. 51):

[...] those who have been highlighting the issues about animal welfare have been ridiculed as emotional activists and extremists or are simply ignored by an industry that has chosen to turn a blind eye to a subject that is far more complicated to deal with due to traditions, cultures, and a lack of industrial awareness.

The few researchers who have shed the light on the consumers' response to animal-friendly products have considered mainly the case of food (De Jonge and Van Trijp, 2013; Verbeke, 2009), and it is surprising to note the lack of academic contributions on this subject in the case of apparel items.

Some authors (Hustvedt *et al.*, 2008) argue that animal welfare is of little importance to consumers when purchasing clothes. Individuals seek for selfish benefits and take into consideration personal and financial needs, such as social recognition and self-respect. Consumers are less likely to associate the health of fiber-producing animals to the quality of the animal fiber products they buy. Also, they give more importance to other responsible attributes, such as child labor, employee mistreatment or imprisonment and minimum wage (Hustvedt *et al.*, 2008). Leire and Thidell (2005) argue that the proximity of the product to the consumer's body or personal activities is a crucial factor in the use of ethical information.

However, in a recent study, Reimers *et al.* (2016) identified four factors that influence consumers' perceptions of ethical clothing items: environmental responsibility, employee welfare,

animal welfare and slow fashion attributes, and confirmed that animal welfare exerts the strongest influence.

2.2 The animal welfare issue in the luxury fashion industry

In the fashion sector, luxury brands have been the most criticized by animal rights activists, who actively communicate via shock campaigns and videos spread on social networks. In response to these critics, some luxury companies have chosen to continue to use animal raw materials while taking responsible actions improving breeding conditions (e.g. Hermès), others have decided to stop using these materials (e.g. Calvin Klein, Stella McCartney, Ralph Lauren, Giorgio Armani, Hugo Boss, Burberry, Gucci). This latter strategic option was welcomed by animal rights activists. Nevertheless, luxury brands that are willing to consider sustainability have to face an important challenge, that of preservation of perceived superior quality. Indeed, a contradiction between "luxury" and "sustainability" could be perceived, leading to a decrease of the quality of eco-luxury products (Dekhili *et al.*, 2019). According to Dekhili and Achabou (2016), while luxury is synonymous of irreproachable quality, sustainability is linked to rationalization and lower quality. Some research works (Griskevicius *et al.*, 2010) precise, however, that responsible luxury products, even when perceived of lower quality, may fulfil the consumer's need for status. By preferring an eco-product of lower quality than a conventional one, the consumers express that they are financially able and willing to incur the cost of helping someone even in the absence of any direct benefit to themselves.

The costly signaling theory (Zahavi, 1975) could help to better understand the trade-off between costs and benefits associated with a purchase decision. It states that individuals often engage in behaviors that are costly as a way of signaling information about themselves. A study by McAndrew (2019) that focuses on capitalistic societies indicates that the most readily observable form of costly signaling is wasteful spending on luxury goods that by definition are not essential for survival in daily life. A person displaying luxury products signals that he/she is wealthy and of a high social status (Berger, 2017). This leads to an advantageous treatment of the signaler in social interactions. For example, individuals wearing expensive branded clothing are more likely to achieve compliance to their requests, be recommended for jobs, and they are more successful when soliciting charitable donations from others (McAndrew, 2019).

As an extension of the luxury-signaling approach, it has been suggested that public prosociality, such as conspicuous generosity or environmentally friendly behavior, works in an analogous way (Berger, 2017). The results obtained by Chance *et al.* (2011) show that donating to a cause led to individuals reporting higher subjective wealth, as the donation signaled to others their prosperity. In the case of environmentally friendly consumption, a typical example of a green signal that has often been cited in the recent literature is that of the hybrid car Toyota Prius. Compared to fuel-powered models in the same price segment, Toyota Prius offers less comfort. This is the cost that makes the signal reliable: only an individual who truly cares about the environment is willing to forgo comfort for the sake of the planet (Berger, 2017). In the same way, Griskevicius *et al.* (2010) assert that by purchasing a Toyota Prius a consumer can

signal to others that he/she is a prosocial and not proself individual. Consequently, the authors refer to “self-sacrifice” concept when describing this behavior.

The acceptance to sacrifice certain benefits related to luxury goods (comfort, superior quality, etc.) is nevertheless not guaranteed in the case of fashion products. As indicated by [Niinimäki and Hassi, 2011](#)), fashion consumers differ from consumers of other product categories when making ethical consumption decision. For instance, [Achabou and Dekhili \(2013\)](#) showed that the replacement of virgin raw materials by recycled ones in a Hermès shirt affects negatively consumers’ preference. Recycling does not appear to be associated with “prestige”. Moreover, consumers perceive luxury branded products to be handmade and authentic as they are manufactured by artisans using time honoured traditions and natural ingredients ([Cheah et al., 2016](#)). In line with this idea, [Lee and Watkins \(2016\)](#) argue that to be considered as “luxury”, brands should contain luxury features (e.g. high quality, prestige, high price, exclusivity) and provide psychological and emotional values.

With this in mind, the limitation of the rate of animal raw materials to include in luxury products, or their replacement by other less prestigious materials, could conduct to negative perceptions. Consequently, we may assume that in the textile industry, the importance of the animal welfare attribute is less important in the case of luxury fashion items. The following hypothesis has been therefore formulated:

- H1.* The consumer preference for animal welfare attribute is less important in the case of luxury fashion brands than in the case of accessible brands.

2.3 The effect of social value orientation on consumer preference for ethical products

Social value orientation (SVO) is “a central personality trait that is closely related to social preferences and prosocial tendencies and that can predict diverse forms of cooperative behavior” ([Yanyan et al., 2020](#), p. 1).

Depending on the importance people attribute to their own and others’ outcomes, diverse types of SVO have been identified, among which individualistic, competitive and prosocial orientations are most common in daily life ([Messick and McClintock, 1968](#)). Individualists tend to maximize self-interests with no (or very little) regard for other’s outcomes; and competitors tend to maximize their relative advantage over others ([Van Prooijen et al., 2008](#)). Individualists and competitors are often taken together as “proselfs”, because both assign more weight to own than to other’s outcomes ([Steinel, 2015](#)).

Prosocials persons, however, tend to maximize joint outcomes and equality in outcomes between themselves and others. In comparison with proselfs, prosocials exhibit more cooperation toward others, expect greater cooperation from others, and tend to interpret others’ behavior more strongly in terms of morality and fairness ([Van Prooijen et al., 2008](#)). In the same vein, [Yanyan et al. \(2020\)](#) indicate that in simulated business relationships, prosocials show greater levels of concession and make more sacrifices. According to [Stenstrom et al. \(2018\)](#), prosocial behavior has long perplexed researchers

because it seems irrational to give one’s scarce resources away for someone else’s benefit. Some scholars have questioned the existence of “true” altruism (behavior driven by authentically selfless motives), whereas others have argued that individuals experience psychological benefits from prosocial behavior ([Johnson and Chattaraman, 2019](#)). [Stenstrom et al. \(2018\)](#) indicate, for their part, that people are generally motivated to reciprocate an act of generosity. Committing a prosocial behavior toward a specific individual could be an effective means of obtaining their future support.

Pro-environmental and social initiatives (donating to charity, contributing money to environmental organizations, signing petitions against environmental harm, etc.) constitute a real-life examples of social dilemmas[1] ([Bogaert et al., 2008](#); [Garling et al., 2003](#)). Acting pro-environmentally involves that people benefit others or the environment, while often these behaviors do not provide any direct individual benefit ([De Groot and Steg, 2009](#)).

An environmental issue that is receiving a lot of attention in the literature is the choice a mean of transportation (car vs public transportation) ([Bogaert et al., 2008](#)). This choice involves a trade-off between immediate self-interest (travel time, flexibility and convenience) and long-term collective benefit (pollution, public health). Researches mobilizing the SVO approach indicate that prosocials usually prefer public transportation whereas proselfs opt for traveling by car. When evaluating a plan related to transportation pollution reduction, proselfs perceive higher personal costs associated with the program and show fewer support compared to prosocials. The results obtained by [Cameron et al. \(1998\)](#), who focused on the peoples’ support (vs opposition) to environmental programs, confirmed the same trend. Proself participants are more inclined to send letters opposing the program because of their stronger focus on personal costs, while prosocial individuals are more likely to send letters of support. According to [De Groot and Steg \(2009\)](#), people with a proself value orientation tend to consider costs and benefits of pro-environmental behavior for them personally: when the perceived benefits exceed the perceived costs they perform an environmentally friendly behavior and vice versa. In contrast, people with strong altruistic values base their decision on behaving pro-environmentally or not on perceived costs and benefits for other people.

Based on the theoretical elements presented above, we postulate the following hypothesis:

- H2.* The animal welfare information has a stronger impact on consumer preference when consumers have prosocial (vs proself) value orientation.

3. Methodology and results

To obtain a comprehensive overview of how animal welfare attribute affects the consumer preference of fashion products, we conducted two quantitative studies. The first one (Study 1), by including two product categories, proposes to measure the importance of this attribute in the case of luxury vs accessible fashion (H1). The second one (Study 2), by considering social value orientation (SVO), examines how the attention given to

animal welfare information could vary between prosocials and proselves (H2).

3.1 Study 1

3.1.1 Method

To test the hypothesis (H1), we carried out conjoint analysis. This technique is among the most popular for measuring consumer preference (Green and Srinivasan, 1990) and is applied to a number of environmental issues (Achabou and Dekhili, 2013).

3.1.2 Selection of attributes, products and brands

Green and Srinivasan (1990) recommend including no more than six attributes in the definition of product profiles in conjoint analysis and limiting the number of levels for each attribute. In our study, we considered three attributes: first, the “proportion of real fur”; the question here is whether the reduction in the use of animal fur in clothes could be positively perceived by consumers. Our choice for animal fur can be justified by the fact that it remains a raw material strongly mobilized in the fashion sector, and that its use is especially strongly criticized.

Second, the “information about animal treatment”. To ensure good control over the production of animal raw materials, several luxury brands have launched plans for the creation or purchase of animal farms. These include a python farm developed by Kering, a crocodile breeding farm set up by LVMH and Hermès, and an animal welfare certification introduced by the Saga Furs auction house in Finland. Through the mobilization of this attribute, we propose to explore whether the display of commitment by fashion brands towards animal welfare is perceived positively by the consumers and whether it reassures them.

The third attribute is “price”. This is a determining factor in the choice of responsible products. Overall, the existing literature shows that consumers are willing to pay premium prices, only when the perceived quality of eco-products is satisfactory (Gam et al., 2010).

Data have been collected in Italy, the world’s most fashionable country thanks to the many big fashion houses located within its territory (Gucci, Versace, Valentino, Armani, etc.). Our experimental design involves two brands with different market positioning: “Kenzo”, a luxury brand; and “Zara”, a more affordable one. The brands selected belong to two leading groups in the fashion sector in Italy. In effect, Inditex group (parent company of Zara) is ranked first, with a turnover of €1.131bn, while LVMH (parent company of Kenzo) is ranked second, with a turnover on the Italian market of €855m (Crivelli, 2016). In addition, the two brands considered have different level of commitment toward animal welfare. Kenzo’s efforts in favor of sustainability emerge from its recent “No fish no Nothing” campaign, launched in partnership with the Blue Marine Foundation, for the protection of marine life, use of sustainable methods of fishing and creation of maritime reserves.

For its part, Zara is one of the most associated brands with social scandals in the global fashion value chain (Perry and Towers, 2013). In recent years, to improve its image, Zara has included sustainability among its main values. With regard to

animal welfare, the Inditex group adopts a policy based on three principles:

- Goods of an animal origin used in the items supplied to the Group shall come from species reared in farms to obtain meat
- Under no circumstances shall animal products deriving from animals slaughtered exclusively to sell their skins, shell, horn, bone, feather or down, be used
- All animals used in such activity shall be treated in an ethical and responsible manner” (Inditex, 2015, p. 5).

3.1.3 Product profile design

The fashion product selected for the conjoint analysis is the “jacket”, as this product is sold for both men and women. It is also the product that most often uses animal fur. We assume that consumers may have different preferences depending on the proportion of real fur used in the selected product. Consequently, we distinguished among three different options: jacket made entirely of real fur (100% real fur), jacket with a high rate of real fur (70% real fur) and jacket with a low rate of real fur (30% real fur). To help consumers distinguish percentages, we added a verbal description mentioning that 30% real fur corresponds to real fur inserts in specific parts of the clothe (on the cuffs and on the neck); and that 70% real fur means that more parts of the jacket were produced by using this material (on the front and on the back). This description, more tangible for the respondents, corresponds to the brands’ practices.

In addition, we included two levels regarding animal treatment attribute: presence of information on the responsible treatment of animals used in the product; absence of information on this attribute.

Finally, we chose three price ranges corresponding to the price levels operated on the Italian market by Kenzo and Zara brands. The attribute levels selected for the analysis are shown in Table 1.

To reduce the number of alternatives we adopted a fractional factorial design using R software. We thus implemented 11 alternatives for each brand, each of them resulting from a different combination of the proportion of real fur, the information on animal treatment and the price level. These alternatives were presented to the respondents in the form of labels (Figure 1). Respondents were asked to assign to each of

Table 1 The levels of the attributes tested

Attributes	Levels	
Proportion of real fur	Jacket made entirely of real fur (100% real fur)	
	Jacket with real fur inserts on the front and on the back (70% real fur)	
	Jacket with real fur inserts on the cuffs and on the neck (30% real fur)	
Animal treatment	The animal-derived materials used come from responsibly raised animals	
	No information	
Price	Kenzo	Zara
	820.00 €	49.99 €
	1,560.00 €	79.99 €
	2,400.00 €	149.99 €

Figure 1 Examples of tested labels

Kenzo jacket	Zara jacket
Made entirely of real fur	With real fur inserts on the front and on the back
The animal-derived materials used come from responsibly raised animals	The animal-derived materials used come from responsibly raised animals
€ 2,400.00	€ 49.99

the 11 alternatives a rating using a Likert scale from 1 (I don't like it at all) to 9 (I like it a lot).

Finally, respondents answered questions on their consumption habits, concerns about environmental and social issues and socio-demographic characteristics. All items for the survey was adapted from established scales measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree". In terms of "environmental concern", it was measured using the scale developed by Thøgersen *et al.* (2010). The scale is derived from the work of Grob (1995) and contains five items showing a satisfactory reliability indicator of approximately 0.80.

To measure social concern, Shen *et al.*'s (2012) six-item scale was used. A reliability index of 0.82 was observed.

3.1.4 Samples

After a pre-test with 138 Italian respondents ($n_{\text{Kenzo}} = 71$; $n_{\text{Zara}} = 67$), the questionnaires were submitted online via the Quick Survey website. Individuals were contacted from December 2015 to May 2016. We opted for a heterogeneous sample including various ages, professions, income levels and ecological concerns. This was facilitated by the fact that the two brands tested are largely diffused.

The total completed questionnaires considered was 224 ($n_{\text{Kenzo}} = 118$; $n_{\text{Zara}} = 106$). The sample size is satisfactory as it fulfills the minimum size of 100 required in the conjoint analysis (Cattin and Wittink, 1982).

In total, 54% of the participants in Zara survey were women (vs 64% in Kenzo case), 36% (vs 34% in Kenzo case) were office workers, 13% (vs 10% in Kenzo case) self-employed, 12% (vs 8% in Kenzo case) manual laborers and 5% (vs 7% in Kenzo case) retired. In terms of income, 63% of the respondents in Zara survey (vs 54% in Kenzo case) earned less than 20000€ annually, nearly one-third of the participants (same rate in Kenzo case) earned between 20000 and 40000€, and 8% of the sample (vs 14% in Kenzo case) earned more than 40000€ (Table 2).

3.1.5 Results

Based on the output of the conjoint analysis conducted, we calculated the relative importance of each attribute, using the following formula:

$$IR_j = \frac{\text{Max}[U_j W_{ji}] - \text{Min}[U_j W_{ji}]}{\sum_{i=1}^k (\text{Max}[U_j W_{ji}] - \text{Min}[U_j W_{ji}])} \quad (1)$$

where IR_j is the relative importance of the j attribute; k is the number of the attributes included in the analysis; $\text{Max}[U_j W_{ji}]$

Table 2 Socio-demographic characteristics of respondents (Study 1, $n = 224$)

Variables	No. of respondents Kenzo survey	No. of respondents Zara survey
Gender		
Male	42	48
Female	76	58
Profession		
Student	0	19
Office worker	40	39
Manual laborer	10	13
Manager	9	0
Self-employed	12	14
Unemployed	4	8
Retired	9	5
Other	34	8
Yearly income		
< 20,000 €	64	67
20,000 – 40,000 €	38	31
> 40,000 €	16	8
Total number of respondents	118	106

is the maximum utility value associated with the W_{ji} level of the " j " attribute of the " i " product profile; $\text{Min}[U_j W_{ji}]$ is the minimum utility value associated with the W_{ji} level of the " j " attribute of the " i " product profile.

In the case of Kenzo, the percentage importance of the three attributes "proportion of real fur", "animal treatment" and "price" are 28.36, 29.98 and 41.67%, respectively. For Zara, the percentage importance is 27.56, 26.96 and 45.48%, respectively. The price is the attribute with the highest level of importance in the case of both brands.

We then examined the utility values of the attribute levels. The respondents' perceptions are positive in the case of the highest real fur rate (utility value = +0.087 for Kenzo and +0.056 for Zara). In contrast when the proportion of real fur decrease, the perceptions of jackets became negative (utility value = -0.028 for Kenzo and -0.031 for Zara in the case of a 30% rate; -0.058 for Kenzo and -0.025 for Zara in the case of a 70% rate).

With regard to the information on animal treatment, the results show that its presence is perceived positively by the respondents (utility estimates = +0.249 for Kenzo and +0.223 for Zara), while the absence of information on animal treatment is associated with a negative level of utility (utility estimate = -0.249 for Kenzo and -0.223 for Zara).

As expected, the lowest prices (€820.00 in the case of Kenzo; €49.99 and €79.99 in the case of Zara) corresponded to the highest level of utility (utility value = +0.190; +0.164 and +0.065 respectively), while the highest prices (€2,400.00 and €1,560.00 in the case of Kenzo; €149.99 for Zara) were associated with a negative level of utility (utility value = -0.153; -0.037 and -0.229, respectively).

The results above indicate no major difference between the two brands in terms of consumer preference for the animal welfare attribute. Therefore, $H1$ is rejected.

To explore the differences in consumer preference for the social attribute tested regarding the individuals' profile, we carried out a cluster analysis using the k-means technique. The variables used to identify the appropriate number of clusters were the utility estimates assigned by the 224 respondents to each product profile. Based on elaboration using R Project software, we retained two clusters (within cluster sum of squares by cluster: 2148.243 1360.04; between_SS/total_SS = 75.4%).

Table 3 presents the relative importance of the attributes in the selected two clusters (Cluster 1: 100 respondents; Cluster 2: 124 respondents).

While for both segments the most important attribute is still the price (relative importance 40.65% for Cluster 1 and 45.75% for Cluster 2), the clusters reveal some differences. Indeed, while the first cluster assigns the greatest importance to information on animal treatment (relative importance of 34.06%, against 24.10% for Cluster 2), the second cluster gives more importance to the proportion of real fur (relative importance of 30.15% against 25.29% for Cluster 1).

For further insight into these findings, we examined the utility values of the attribute levels in the two clusters (**Table 4**).

The first cluster assigns higher utility values to the proportion of real fur (utility value for 100% real fur = 0.100 vs 0.049 in the case of Cluster 2) and to animal treatment (utility value = 0.378 vs 0.123 in the case of Cluster 2).

The results clearly suggest that consumers in Cluster 1 support the continued use of animal fur in clothing and are reassured by the fact that fur is coming from animals treated responsibly. In Cluster 2, the low values given to the percentage of real fur could be explained by consumers' desire to reduce the use of this material in clothing. The information on responsible farming does not seem to convince them completely.

Table 3 Relative importance of the attributes in the two clusters selected (Study 1)

Attributes	Cluster 1	Cluster 2
Proportion of real fur	25,29%	30,15%
Animal treatment	34,06%	24,10%
Price	40,65%	45,75%

Table 4 Utility values of the attributes in the two clusters (Study 1)

Attributes	Levels	Cluster 1	Cluster 2
Proportion of real fur	100% real fur	0.100	0.049
	70% real fur	-0.052	-0.035
	30% real fur	-0.048	-0.014
Animal treatment	The company declares that the animal-derived materials used come from responsibly raised animals	0.378	0.123
	No information	-0.378	-0.123
Price	Low	0.148	0.202
	Medium	0.094	-0.055
	High	-0.242	-0.146
Intercept		5.821	1.614

Moreover, the analysis of the consumer declarations on the importance they attach to choice criteria when purchasing a fashion product reveals some differences between clusters. Cluster 1 seems to give more importance to the brand (average score: 3.2 vs 2.5 for Cluster 2), while Cluster 2 considers more the made-in and ecolabel (average scores: 3.5 and 3.3 vs 2.8 and 2.7, respectively for Cluster 1).

Finally, regarding the socio-demographic features, the two clusters are similar in terms of average age (38.7 years old in Cluster 1 and 35.8 in Cluster 2). However, Cluster 2 is mostly composed of women (74% vs 42% in Cluster 1).

3.2 Study 2

3.2.1 Method and sample

To examine the effect of consumers social value orientation on the importance of animal welfare attribute when purchasing fashion products, we conducted a conjoint and a cluster analysis. Study 2 replicated Study 1, testing the differences between prosocials and proselfs.

As Study 1 showed no difference between the two brands tested (luxury vs affordable), we took in Study 2 only one product into consideration: Kenzo jackets. Indeed, luxury fashion industry is the largest user of animal raw materials, including those very scarce (Dekhili *et al.*, 2019).

After evaluating the 11 Kenzo product profiles used in Study 1, the participants to Study 2 answered questions concerning their social value orientation and perceived sacrifice, in addition to those related to socio-demographic characteristics and consumers' environmental and social concerns. All items for Study 2 was adapted from established scales measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree".

To measure prosocial orientation, Webb *et al.*'s (2000) four-item scale was adopted. Proself values were measured using Eastman *et al.*'s (1999) five-item scale. In terms of perceived sacrifice, it was measured using the four-item scale developed by Rodier *et al.* (2012).

The questionnaires were submitted online via the Quick Survey website from November 2019 to January 2020, and involved Italian consumers. After eliminating uncompleted responses, the total number of respondents considered was 101. The characteristics of the sample are summarized in **Table 5**.

3.2.2 Results

The percentage importance of the three attributes "proportion of real fur", "animal treatment" and "price" are 27.94, 30.19 and 41.87%, respectively.

We observe that a luxury-clothing product made entirely from real fur is perceived positively by consumers (utility value = +0.074). When the real fur rate decreases, the perceptions became negative (utility value = -0.023 in the case of a 30% rate; -0.052 in the case of a 70% real fur rate). In addition, the presence of information on animal treatment is perceived favorably (utility value = +0.310). As expected, the lowest price corresponds to the highest level of utility (utility value = +0.205).

To test the effect of prosocial and proself values, we carried out a cluster analysis using the k-means technique. The variables used to identify the appropriate number of clusters were the utility estimates assigned by the 101 respondents to

Table 5 Socio-demographic characteristics of respondents (Study 2, $n = 101$)

Variables	No. of respondents
Gender	
Male	36
Female	64
Profession	
Student	15
Office worker	51
Manual laborer	2
Manager	3
Self-employed	19
Unemployed	1
Retired	3
Other	7
Yearly income	
< 20,000 €	31
20,000 – 40,000 €	51
> 40,000 €	19
Total number of respondents	101

each product profile. Based on elaboration using R Project software, we retained two clusters (within cluster sum of squares by cluster: 1121.3766 697.0486; between_SS/total_SS = 64%). **Table 6** indicates the relative importance of the attributes in the two clusters (Cluster 1: 48 respondents; Cluster 2: 53 respondents).

Cluster 1 considers price as very important (45.05%), while animal treatment and proportion of real fur are quite important (28.73 and 26.22%, respectively). In Cluster 2, even though price is important, its relative importance is lower than in Cluster 1 (39.03%). Animal treatment and proportion of real fur gain 31.49 and 29.48%, respectively.

We now examine the utility values of the attribute levels in the two clusters considered (**Table 7**).

Table 7 shows that Cluster 2 is more sensitive to the presence of information on animal treatment (utility value = +0.320 vs +0.299 for Cluster 1). Also, consumers in Cluster 2 valorize lesser clothes made entirely from animal fur (utility value = +0.058 vs +0.092 for Cluster 1) and are less reluctant to the reduction of real fur in luxury jackets (utility values = -0.043 in the case of 70% real fur; -0.015 in the case of 30% real fur vs -0.061 and -0.031, respectively, for Cluster 1).

The examination of consumers' values in the two clusters will help to determine the link between the consumers' preference for animal welfare and their social orientation. As indicated in **Table 8**, the individuals in Cluster 2 expressing a higher preference for animal welfare and ethical clothes are more prosocials than their counterparts in Cluster 1 ($M_{\text{Prosocial values}}$

Table 6 Relative importance of the attributes in the two clusters selected (Study 2)

Attributes	Cluster 1	Cluster 2
Proportion of real fur	26.22%	29.48%
Animal treatment	28.73%	31.49%
Price	45.05%	39.03%

Table 7 Utility values of the attributes in the two clusters (Study 2)

Attributes	Levels	Cluster 1	Cluster 2
Proportion of real fur	100% real fur	0.092	0.058
	70% real fur	-0.061	-0.043
	30% real fur	-0.031	-0.015
Animal treatment	The company declares that the animal-derived materials used come from responsibly raised animals	0.299	0.320
	No information	-0.299	-0.320
Price	Low	0.182	0.225
	Medium	0.125	-0.108
	High	-0.308	-0.117
Intercept		5.462	1.795

Cluster2 = 4.28 and $M_{\text{Prosocial values Cluster1}} = 3.62$; $p < 0.05$). In the same sense, proself values are less important in Cluster 2 compared to Cluster 1 ($M_{\text{Proself values Cluster2}} = 2.15$ and $M_{\text{Proself values Cluster1}} = 3.08$; $p < 0.05$). In addition, **Table 8** highlights a lesser perceived sacrifice in the case of Cluster 2 ($M_{\text{Perceived sacrifice Cluster2}} = 2.48$ and $M_{\text{Perceived sacrifice Cluster1}} = 3.03$; $p < 0.05$), which is in line with the importance this group gave to the price (**Table 6**: Cluster 2 is less sensitive to the price of animal-friendly fashion products).

Based on the costly signaling theory, this indicates that individuals in Cluster 2 are more willing to sacrifice other benefits (e.g. quality, comfort, status ...) in favour of animal-friendly fashion consumption.

These results allow us to accept *H2*.

In our analysis, we also measured consumers' sustainable concerns. Not surprisingly, individuals in Cluster 2 show a higher social ($M_{\text{Soc sensitivity Cluster2}} = 4.18$ and $M_{\text{Soc sensitivity Cluster1}} = 3.61$; $p < 0.05$) and environmental ($M_{\text{Env sensitivity Cluster2}} = 4.14$ and $M_{\text{Env sensitivity Cluster1}} = 3.42$; $p < 0.05$) sensitivity.

Finally, looking at the socio-demographic characteristics, the two clusters are similar in terms of average age (35.7 years old in Cluster 1 and 36.7 in Cluster 2). However, and as in Study 1, Cluster 2 comprises a majority of women (72% vs 54% in Cluster 1).

4. Discussion and theoretical contributions

This research includes several major findings. First, it contributes to the limited literature on the influence of animal welfare information on consumer preferences for fashion products. The results obtained indicate that the price remains a decisive selection criterion in the case of textile items, which is more important than social characteristics. Such findings support the conclusions of **Pookulangara and Shephard (2013)** who state that, although fashion consumers show a positive attitude toward the protection of the planet, they rarely transform such attitude into eco-fashion consumption; instead, they continue to seek cheap and fast fashion. In the same line as **Verbeke (2009)**, we assume that consumers of fashion products consider the animal welfare attribute only as a supporting benefit. In addition, because of the lack of transparency of most

Table 8 Consumers' social value orientation and perceived sacrifice in the two clusters (Study 2)

	Alpha	Cluster 1 Mean	SD	Alpha	Cluster 2 Mean	SD
Prosocial values	0.951	3.62	0.86	0.920	4.28	0.765
People should be willing to help others who are less fortunate						
Helping troubled people with their problems is very important to me						
People should be more charitable toward others in society						
People in need should receive support from others						
Proself values	0.920	3.08	1.06	0.915	2.15	1.126
I would buy a product just because it has status						
I am interested in new products with status						
I would pay more for a product if it had status						
The status of a product is irrelevant to me						
A products is more valuable to me if it has some snob appeal						
Perceived sacrifice	0.920	3.03	0.903	0.929	2.48	1.000
I doubt the effectiveness of eco-fashion products						
I am suspicious of the performance of eco-fashion products						
I have doubts about the level of performance of eco-fashion products						
Eco-fashion are not of the same quality as conventional products						

fashion firms, consumers are not aware of the problems of animal cruelty associated with the textile industry. Indeed, the adoption of a responsible consumption requires certain level of consumer knowledge (Gardetti, 2017).

Second, the investigation of the consumer behavior towards animal-friendly fashion products contributes to the costly signaling theory as it demonstrates that, globally, consumers continue to prefer products made entirely from animal fur. They do not seem willing to sacrifice their need for appearance and ostentation (cost of the signal) in favor of an individual prosocial status. According to Woodside (2012), in the fashion sector, several consumers seek principally to fulfill their need for conspicuousness. More particularly, fur is one of the material that best meets this need:

When you wear fur, you have to assume it right through to the end, but without vulgarity You have to wear fur like Alexis in Dynasty or Samantha in Sex and The City, by totally assuming its conspicuous nature (Ricou, 2014).

However, our result does not concur with the conclusions of Griskevicius *et al.* (2010) suggesting that altruistic acts could be used to signal prosocial value, rather than proself value of the individual.

Third, by considering the contributions of the literature on social value orientation (Study 2), our research provides a better understanding of the attitude-behavior gap in animal-friendly fashion consumption. Individuals with a high level of prosocial values (low level of proself values) give more importance to the animal welfare attribute and are less reluctant to the reduction of the proportion of real fur in the clothes. Proself consumers associate a higher sacrifice with the consumption of animal-friendly fashion products. The perceived sacrifice/cost is greater in the particular case of luxury products because of their important role as a social marker. These results are consistent with the assumption of De Groot and Steg (2009) mentioning that proself values play an important role especially in the case of high behavioral costs related to responsible actions.

Fourth, our findings suggest that the mention of information on animal treatment reassures consumers and contributes to the development of self-indulgence rather than self-sacrifice (Johnson *et al.*, 2018). The consumers consider that, as long as the fur comes from well-treated animals, they can continue to use products made entirely from animal raw materials and thus meet their dual needs: aesthetics expectation and the need to be perceived as a socially responsible person. Information on satisfactory farming conditions allows consumers to neutralize information on behavior considered unethical – the purchase of products made entirely from animal raw materials – (Haug and Busch, 2016). Thus, this research contributes to the cognitive dissonance theory (Festinger, 1957) through illustrating the trivialization mode of dissonance reduction (Simon *et al.*, 1995). To reduce the discomfort related to a dissonant consumption situation (here the desire to consume clothes from real fur is in contradiction with a responsible behavior), individuals tend to devalue the problematic behavior. In this way, our result refers to the concept of individualization that supports self-expressive consumption (Sudbury and Böltner, 2011). As Bennett and Chakravarti (2008) have emphasized, the valorization of green products is determined not only by their social benefits but also by their self-signaling potential.

Finally, our research confirm that women are less reluctant to the reduction of real fur in clothes than men. In this regard, there is a consensus in the literature that women are globally more sensitive to environmental and social issues. Dekhili and Achabou (2014) asserted that women have a better understanding and greater knowledge of responsible products. In the specific case of textile products, Niinimäki and Hassi (2011) argued that women are more concerned by ethical issues. In this vein, Griskevicius *et al.* (2010) confirmed that men are generally more concerned about status-striving and are more likely to engage in “show off” displays than women. Similarly, Truong (2010) indicated that men are more influenced than women by social prestige, image, wealth display and social recognition.

5. Practical implications

Our results confirmed that social attributes still constitute a secondary decisive selection criterion. To convince consumers about the importance of animal welfare attribute and increase their preference for animal-friendly fashion products, companies have several strategic options. First, the partners of the company should be chosen with caution. In this way, Stella McCartney is a very illustrative example: the brand, with a business model founded on ethics, signed a partnership with Adidas, involved in sweatshop controversy, to provide the UK kit for the 2012 London Olympics (Marati, 2012). Within a context of consumer skepticism toward ecological discourse, fashion companies should ensure that the brand projects a consistent ethical image (Phau *et al.*, 2015).

Second, it is in the best interests of fashion brands to review their relationships with suppliers in developing countries. Textile companies have to be aware that the country of origin of raw materials could damage brand image through a negative publicity (Cheah *et al.*, 2016). For instance, the scandal of animal cruelty involving the wool supplier “Estancia La Librun” may call into question the sincerity of the ethical commitment of Stella McCartney and Patagonia. Fashion companies can no longer simply impose codes of conduct as the coordination model can lead to deviant behavior by suppliers to avoid the costs associated with compliance to environmental and social standards (Lim and Phillips, 2008). Thus, fashion brands are encouraged to develop close relationships with their suppliers and help them to adopt ecological standards by strengthening their management capacities and cooperating with local resources in developing countries (Lund-Thomsen and Lindgreen, 2014).

Moreover, vertical integration is a viable option. It has been, for example, considered by Hermès and LVMH, that bought crocodile farms in Australia, giving them better control over the quality of the raw material supplied, as well as over the animal husbandry conditions.

In Italy, some initiatives have been adopted. For instance, the Camera Nazionale della Moda Italiana (National Chamber of Italian Fashion) published in 2012 a ten-point guide for the development of responsible management models along the entire value chain of the fashion industry “Sustainability Manifesto for Italian Fashion”. This guide includes specific indications on choosing materials derived from traceable crops that have a lower environmental impact (for vegetable fibers) and that respect animals’ welfare (for animal fibers, hides and fine materials).

Third, a strategy of labelling to promote favorable animal treatment conditions would be effective. In particular, luxury companies could develop, through their trade union organizations (e.g. Comité Colbert in France), a label certifying that the raw materials of animal origin used in their products come from responsible farms. While consumers are increasingly suspicious of environmental displays, the strong image of luxury brands can reassure them regarding the credibility of ecolabels (Dekhili and Achabou, 2014). Consumers trust brands with good reputation because they consider that known companies cannot risk damaging their advantageous images by adopting greenwashing practices.

Fourth, enterprises should consider the consumer egoistic motivation to enhance the value of products comprising sustainable substitute materials. In the case of companies that cannot control animal husbandry conditions and therefore choose to replace animal raw materials with, for example, synthetic materials, we believe that marketers should associate products with status. As Griskevicius *et al.* (2010) have emphasized, the activation of status motives might produce prosocial/pro-environmental tendencies. Relating to this point, the selling prices of products using substitutes to animal raw materials must be high. In accordance with the costly signaling theory, purchasing expensive green products can strengthen persons’ ability to signal wealth (Johnson *et al.*, 2018).

Fifth, to promote their products containing substitute raw materials, in particular among proself consumers, luxury companies should adopt persuasion messages that reduce perceptions of the personal cost induced by social actions (e.g. the decrease of perceived quality in the case of replacement of animal raw materials), rather than focus principally on the expected social benefice. This idea is in line with Cameron *et al.*’s (1998) recommendation in the case of transportation sector. The authors found that messages highlighting the environmental benefits are less effective in supporting transportation pollution-reduction programs than messages focusing on personal benefits of carpooling (e.g. reduced transportation costs, extra personal time during the commute). In the luxury sector, an interesting example of reducing the consumer’s perception of a sacrifice/cost related to the use of new substitute raw materials is that of Stella McCartney. The Founder of the brand highlights the importance to consider intrinsic attributes (e.g. style, prestige) when offering an animal-friendly product:

I think one of the biggest compliments is when I know people go in and buy a Falabella bag or a pair of shoes, or a faux leather skirt, and they have no idea they’re not real leather. I think that’s really where it becomes sexy. Where you’re not just providing an alternative...you’re creating a great product (Stella McCartney, official website).

Finally, our research reveals the importance of educating consumers about animal welfare issue. Although some respondents mention their awareness of the animal abuse in the fashion industry, this does not appear to influence significantly their purchase decision. To reduce the attitude-behavior gap, we believe that emotion-based communication could better help to raise individual awareness compared to rationality and morality arguments. Eckhardt *et al.* (2010) indicated that television documentaries on child exploitation in carpet manufacturing in developing countries have increased the ethical sensitivity of Swedish and German persons.

6. Limitations and future avenues of research

Although this research provides several theoretical and managerial contributions, it has some limitations that offer perspectives for future investigations. First, the study used convenience sample, and considered Italian consumers only, whereas the consumption of fashion products depends on the individuals’ culture. Replicating this research with representative consumer samples from different countries is necessary. Then, even if the pre-test mentioned the need to give participants precised information regarding the percentage of 70 and 30 of real fur in addition to the products’ profiles, we

can assume that this information may have biased the consumers' responses. Consequently, other kind of presentations reducing the differences between the various percentages should be set up. Moreover, given that the animal welfare effect remains little studied to date in the marketing literature, one new line of research would be to explore how the integration of innovative environmentally-friendly materials can be accepted by the target. The example of textile made of Pinatex, a pineapple leaf fibres that constitutes an alternative to animal leather, seems interesting to be examined.

Another limitation is that only one product category (clothing) was tested. To enhance the external validity of our results, further studies should determine the extent to which the low valorization of the social dimension identified in the case of jackets could cover other product categories.

Finally, a promising line of research would be to seek new insights into the way of adapting communication on eco-products to the consumer profile. Our results confirmed that animal welfare information has a stronger impact on preference when individuals have prosocial (vs proself) value orientation. In this sense, 4.0 technologies could help to optimize the information to provide to consumers. It would thus be useful to investigate the example of smart ecolabels as they could offer filtered information. Prosocials may be exposed, for instance, to information on production conditions and animal treatment conditions when they read the smart ecolabel, while proselfs could have access to specific information as the product quality.

Note

- 1 Social dilemmas are situations in which people are confronted with a choice between personal and collective benefits (Kaiser and Byrka, 2011).

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